

Flamingos

Order *Phoenicopteriformes*

Puna flamingo

Phoenicoparrus jamesi

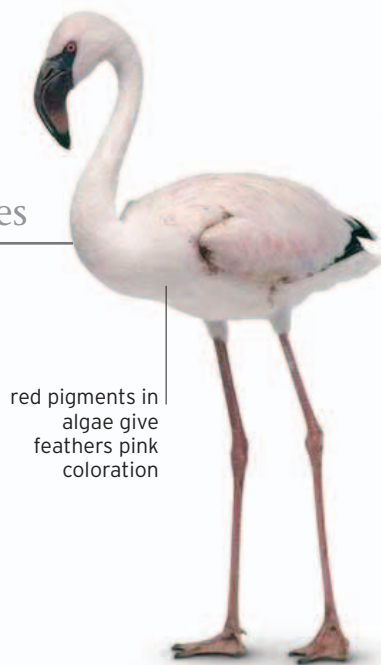
- ↔ 4 ft (1.1m)
- 📍 W. South America
- ⊗ Near threatened

Also known as James' flamingo, this was once believed to be extinct, but in 1956, it was discovered in a remote part of the Andes. It lives in the salt lakes of the high Andean plateau—locally known as the puna—where it feeds on microscopic algae by sifting the water through filters in its bill. The female lays a single egg on a mound of mud, and both parents feed the chick.

red pigments in algae give feathers pink coloration

Other species

- **Greater flamingo**
Phoenicopterus roseus » p149
- **Lesser flamingo**
Phoenicopterus minor » p188



Herons and relatives

Order *Ciconiiformes*

Gray heron

Ardea cinerea

- ↔ 35–39 in (90–98 cm)
- 📍 Europe, Asia, Africa
- ⊗ Common

Found in wetlands throughout most of its range, this tall, long-legged bird typically hunts in shallow water, either wading slowly or watching for prey such as fish. On spotting a victim, it darts its head forward on its long neck to seize it in its sharp bill and swallows it whole. Gray herons usually nest high in trees in small colonies; they pair for life, returning to the same nest each spring.

American bittern

Botaurus lentiginosus

- ↔ 24–34 in (61–86 cm)
- 📍 North and Central America, Caribbean
- ⊗ Common

The American bittern is a type of heron but with a shorter neck and legs. This marshland bird is camouflaged among dense reedbeds, with streaked and mottled brown plumage. If disturbed, it enhances the effect by standing with its neck extended and bill pointing up, and even swaying in the wind with the surrounding reeds.

Wood stork

Mycteria americana

- ↔ 34–43 in (85–100 cm)
- 📍 North, Central, and South America, Caribbean
- ⊗ Common

One of the largest North American wading birds, the wood stork is white with a black tail and flight feathers. It has a naked, dark gray head and a long, heavy gray bill, which it uses to probe in the mud for food. It feels for prey such as fish with its sensitive bill tip and snaps up any animal it touches. It favors wooded marshland habitats, resting and nesting in the trees.

Sacred ibis

Threskiornis aethiopicus

- ↔ 26–35 in (66–89 cm)
- 📍 Sub-Saharan Africa, Madagascar, Aldabra Island, W. Asia
- ⊗ Common

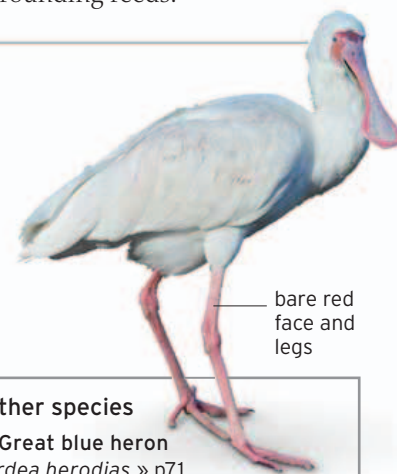
Similar to the wood stork, with white plumage, black legs and tail, and a naked black head and neck, this bird has a long, downcurved bill adapted for searching wet mud for prey. However, it has learned to exploit other food resources, including carrion and edible refuse. It also stalks across grasslands in the wake of fires, looking for animals killed by the flames.

African spoonbill

Platalea alba

- ↔ 30–36 in (76–91 cm)
- 📍 Sub-Saharan Africa, Madagascar
- ⊗ Common

Like all spoonbills, this graceful, red-legged white bird is specially adapted for feeding in shallow water by sweeping the spoon-shaped tip of its long bill from side to side to snap up shrimp and other small animals. It may also create currents that bring small fish within striking range. The broad bill develops as the bird grows; when it hatches, it has a short bill resembling that of an ibis.



bare red face and legs

Other species

- **Great blue heron**
Ardea herodias » p71
- **Jabiru stork**
Jabiru mycteria » p103
- **Roseate spoonbill**
Platalea ajaja » p104

Pelicans and relatives

Order *Pelecaniformes*

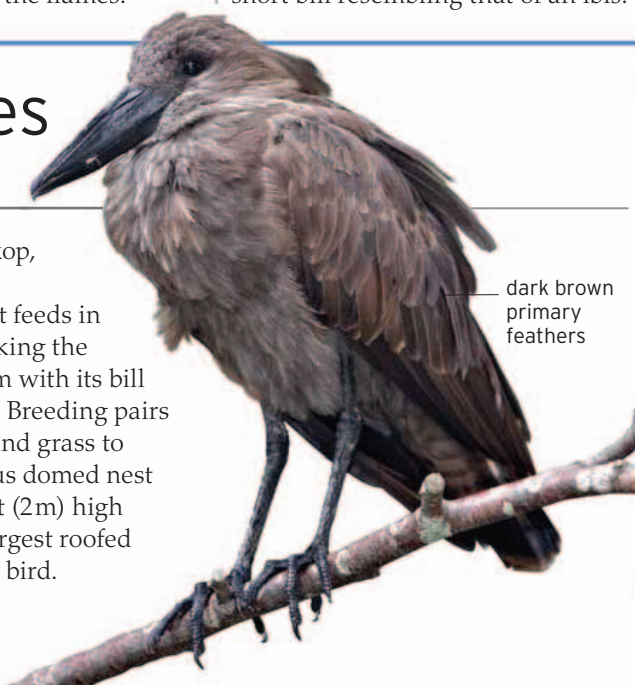
Hamerkop

Scopus umbretta

- ↔ 16–22 in (40–56 cm)
- 📍 Sub-Saharan Africa, Madagascar, SW. Asia
- ⊗ Common

The short, heavy bill and long crest of this brown bird give its head an unusual shape; this is reflected in

the name hamerkop, which means “hammerhead.” It feeds in shallow water, raking the mud at the bottom with its bill for frogs and fish. Breeding pairs use twigs, mud, and grass to build an enormous domed nest in a tree, up to 6 ft (2m) high and wide—the largest roofed nest made by any bird.



dark brown primary feathers

Great cormorant

Phalacrocorax carbo

- ↔ 32–39 in (80–100 cm)
- 📍 E. North America, S. Greenland, Europe, Asia, Southern Africa, Australia
- ⊗ Common

A specialized fisheater, this goose-sized bird can swallow a large eel whole. It pursues its prey underwater, propelling itself on large webbed feet. Its loose plumage is easily wetted, allowing water to penetrate and reduce its buoyancy for easy diving.